

Open Knowledge for a Sustainable Future: Research, Ethics, and Wikipedia

Week 1 (Academic + Wiki) — Course Overview & Framing

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Today

- 1 Course Overview
- 2 Why Academic Writing Matters
- 3 Global Structure
- 4 Evidence and Sources (lecture 3)
- 5 Ethics, Integrity, Openness (lecture 5)
- 6 Process: Revision and Feedback (Lecture 7)
- 7 General Advice: Common Mistakes & Checklist
- 8 (Wiki) Orientation & Onboarding

Roadmap

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What This Course Is About

- Academic vs. encyclopedic writing (audience, voice, structure)
- Sustainable knowledge: FAIR / CARE, openness, ethics
- Practice both: (Academic) paper and (Wiki) article
- Learn transferrable skills: argument, evaluation, revision, collaboration

Two Tracks, One Goal

(Academic) Short paper (4-8 pp + refs)

- Argument-driven, thesis-focused
- Synthesis and analysis
- Scholarly voice & citation norms
- Writing part of a larger process

(Wiki) Wikipedia article

- NPOV, verifiability, no original research
- Clear structure; accessibility
- Community standards, consensus

- We **compare genres** to strengthen writing and judgment.

Academic vs. Encyclopedic Writing (Quick Contrast)

- **Audience:** specialists vs. general public
- **Purpose:** advance/argue vs. summarize established knowledge
- **Voice:** hedged, theory-aware vs. neutral, accessible
- **Evidence:** engage literature vs. cite reliable secondary sources
- **Structure:** IMRaD/thesis vs. lede + sections

- **Academic paper (Francis):** 4-8 pages + references; peer review; revision memo
 - ▶ Review two articles
- **Wikipedia article (Pavel):** sandbox draft; sourcing; feedback; mainspace
 - ▶ Comment on two articles
- **Participation:** discussion, reflections

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Why It Matters

- It **helps thinking**: analysis, structure, precision
- It **builds knowledge**: claims + evidence + reasoning
- It **travels**: others can reuse, critique, extend
- It **signals credibility**: method, transparency, sources
- It **connects communities**: researchers, practitioners, public
- It **enables openness**: FAIR data and reusable prose

Write for your Audience

- **Discipline expectations:** terminology, typical arguments
- **Background knowledge:** what can be assumed?
 - ▶ Different disciplines are interested in different things (not always sensibly)
- **Background knowledge:** what can be assumed?
 - ▶ You can assume some shared knowledge
 - ▶ No need to explain everything
- **Motivation:** what problem are they trying to solve?
 - ▶ Are you writing for basic research? understanding
 - ▶ Applied research? better practice
 - ▶ Literary studies? better appreciation
 - ▶ Fine arts? engage an audience
 - ▶ ...

Define Your Purpose

- Explain, evaluate, compare, propose, synthesize?
- Purpose drives selection of evidence and structure
- One paper should have, one clear purpose
 - ▶ **Specific:** a claim you can support in a short paper
 - ▶ **Contestable:** not a truism; invites argument
 - ▶ **Roadmap:** hints at reasons/structure to come

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Common Structures

- Humanities: **thesis-driven essay**
- Social sciences: **IMRaD**
Intro → Methods → Results → Discussion → Conclusion.
- Linguistics:
Intro → Background → Data/Methods → Analysis → Discussion → Conclusion
- Computer Science:
Intro → Related Work → Method → Data → Experiments/Results → Analysis → Conclusion
- Hybrids: literature review + case study; policy analysis + recommendations

- The Introduction sets the stage
 - ▶ Context → Problem → Question/Claim → Contribution → Roadmap
 - ▶ Avoid: history lessons without focus; claims with no stakes
- The Conclusion drives home the argument
 - ▶ Answer the question; synthesize findings
 - ▶ State implications, limits, next steps
 - ▶ **Avoid**: repeating the intro; new evidence in the last paragraph

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How to choose evidence

- What can be trusted as evidence?
 - ▶ Peer-reviewed articles; scholarly books
 - ▶ Policy reports; official statistics; reputable NGOs
 - ▶ Data (quantitative/qualitative), corpora, case studies
- Evaluating Sources (Academic Lens)
 - ▶ **Authority**: who wrote it? venue? peer review?
 - ▶ **Recency/Relevance**: up-to-date, on-point
 - ▶ **Method/Transparency**: can you inspect or replicate?

Integrating Sources

- **Summarize:** key point in your words, with citation
- **Paraphrase:** reframe to serve your argument
- **Quote:** sparingly, when wording is crucial
- Always connect source to **your** claim
- Multiple sources are best
 - ▶ Weave multiple sources to make a new point
 - ▶ Compare/contrast findings, methods, assumptions
 - ▶ Identify gaps, tensions, implications

Multilingual Source Literacy

- Often sources in other languages are ignored
- When English is not the richest source: local journals, government docs, linguistic data, ...
- Beware translation bias; summarize fairly
- Cross-check facts across languages

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- Cite all sources (including data, images)
 - ▶ Read what you cite, don't cite transitively (or acknowledge when you do)
 - ▶ Cite in detail — give page numbers (especially for books)
- Proper paraphrase: change structure and wording, cite anyway
- Avoid patchwriting; keep notes disciplined

Responsible Use of AI Tools

- AI can help brainstorm, outline, surface references
- **You** are responsible for accuracy, reasoning, and citation
- Disclose use where appropriate; never fabricate sources

Sustainable Knowledge (Why Open?)

This is more about data then writing, but still very important.

- **FAIR**: Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Reusable Wilkinson et al., 2016
- **CARE**: Collective benefit, Authority, Responsibility, Ethics Carroll et al., 2020
- **Open Science** (UNESCO Recommendation) UNESCO, 2021
- **Knowledge equity** (Wikimedia 2030) Wikimedia Foundation, 2020

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Writing is Revising

- Draft fast; revise for structure, then style
 - ▶ **Content is more important than presentation**
- Read aloud; reverse outline; get feedback early
- Track changes; keep a revision log

Peer Review is part of the process

- Helpful feedback
 - ▶ Focus on **claims, evidence, logic**, not just grammar
 - ▶ Ask: what is the thesis? is it supported? what is missing?
 - ▶ Offer specific, actionable suggestions
 - ▶ Don't be [reviewer three](#)
Do not: Use a negative or dismissive tone; Ask for unreasonable revisions; Provide little or no constructive guidance; Let personal bias color the review.
- Responding to Feedback
 - ▶ Separate criticism into categories (structure, evidence, style)
 - ▶ Decide: change, clarify, or justify (with reasons)
 - ▶ Write a brief **revision memo**: what changed and why

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Common Mistakes

- Topic Too Broad
 - ▶ Fix: narrow to a focused question you can answer with available evidence
- Claim Without Evidence
 - ▶ Fix: support with sources, data, or analysis; show how evidence bears on the claim
- Source Dump
 - ▶ Fix: synthesize; explain why each source matters *for your thesis*
- Structure Drift
 - ▶ Fix: reverse outline; re-order sections to match argumentative flow
- Jargon Overload
 - ▶ Fix: define key terms once; prefer plain English/Czech unless precision demands technical terms

Pre-Submission Checklist

- Clear thesis in the introduction
- Section headings reflect argumentative moves
- Each paragraph has a topic sentence and a purpose
- Claims are cited; sources are integrated (not just quoted)
- Figures/tables are labeled and discussed
- Proofread for clarity, concision, coherence
- What Good Work Looks Like
 - ▶ **Clarity:** readers always know the claim & why it matters
 - ▶ **Evidence:** claims anchored to credible sources
 - ▶ **Ethics:** accurate attribution; respectful tone; UCoC compliance
 - ▶ **Sustainability:** work that others can find, reuse, build upon

A Minimal Model Outline

- **Abstract** (150–200 words)
- **Introduction**: context, question, thesis, roadmap
- **Body**: 2–3 sections building your case
- **Conclusion**: answer, implications, limits
- **References**: consistent style

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(Wiki) Ground Rules

- Wikipedia **Five pillars** Wikipedia contributors, 2025
- **UCoC**: Universal Code of Conduct Wikimedia Foundation, 2021
- **Programs & Events Dashboard** enrollment Wiki Education, 2025
- Starter modules: editing basics, sourcing, plagiarism

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